December 1983 with the help of the SGPC chairman G.S. Tohra, who was still nursing ambitions of becoming chief minister of Punjab for which he was soliciting Bhindranwale's support.

Sermons on the roof

Soon after shifting to the Akal Takht, Bhindranwale started holding his darbar (congregation) on the langar roof, delivering sermons which were mostly anti-Hindu in content. Sometimes he would criticize Indira Gandhi by using derogatory names. His tape-recorded speeches, spewing venom, were freely available at shops and were actively distributed in villages, unrestricted by the police. He and his posse of armed men would walk across from the Akal Takht building to the langar roof very casually, as if there was no fear of any action by security forces.

Conscious of the fact that he was being criticized by many as an agent of the Congress party, Bhindranwale described his critics as 'power hungry' individuals out to destroy the unity of the 'panth' (synonymous with Sikhs as a religious group). He soon started demanding implementation of the Anandpur Sahib Resolution in its entirety, favouring greater devolution of power to states. He also exhorted every Sikh village to raise a group of three baptized, motorcycle-riding Sikhs armed with revolvers.

This last bit caused Longowal to issue a statement criticizing it and to Bhindranwale's call in general to Sikhs to support terrorism. Soon afterwards, on India's Republic Day (26 January 1984), the Khalistan flag was flown on a building close to the Golden Temple. To match Bhindranwale's utterances, Akali Dal leaders also demanded an amendment to Article 25 of the Indian Constitution, which mentioned that reference to Hindus included persons professing the Sikh, Jain and Buddhist religions. This was neither a part of the Akali Dal's original demands nor a part of the Anandpur Sahib Resolution. To up the ante, Akali Dal leaders announced that if their demand was not met they would burn copies of the Indian Constitution. They also decided to launch an agitation reviving their original demands. As a result, other than Longowal, senior Akali leaders, including Badal and Tohra, were arrested and sent to jail.